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November 11, 2025

Hiring Committee
Cost Assessment and Program Evaluation (CAPE)
U.S. Department of Defense
Washington, DC

Dear Hiring Committee,

I am writing to express my interest in the Operations Research Analyst / Economist position at CAPE. I am a Ph.D. candidate in the Department of Economics at Johns Hopkins University (advisors: Christopher D. Carroll, Nicholas W. Papageorge, and Stelios Fourakis), and I expect to receive my degree in May 2026. My primary specializations are macroeconomic modeling, wealth and income dynamics, and computational economics.

My research agenda focuses on the ability of macroeconomic models to generate empirically realistic distributions of wealth and income over the life cycle. A key driver of that work is modeling heterogeneity in the rate of return on assets, and understanding how return dispersion contributes to portfolio accumulation across households. These themes connect closely to CAPE's mission of providing rigorous, data-driven analysis to inform defense acquisition, program evaluation, cost-benefit analyses, and strategic economic assessments.

In my job-market paper, I calibrate a life-cycle heterogeneous-agent model to match wealth moments from the Survey of Consumer Finances by allowing households to differ in their portfolio returns. The model helps explain observed wealth concentration and return dispersion. In a related project using the Health and Retirement Study, I examine how trust influences both income growth and asset returns — finding a hump-shaped relationship for returns, and characterizing the distribution of the persistent component of returns to net worth. These experiences equip me to (i) frame research strategies and design modelling approaches; (ii) execute econometric and simulation analysis with large micro-data sets; and (iii) translate results into clear, rigorous written deliverables for academic, policy, and practitioner audiences.

I am particularly drawn to the Operations Research Analyst / Economist role at CAPE because it mandates (among other things): econometric modelling, forecasting, cost-benefit and policy analyses, and the translation of data into actionable insights for national-level decision-making. I am confident that my quantitative toolkit and modelling background equip me to undertake those tasks with precision and clarity.

I believe I would be a strong fit at CAPE because:

1. My experience with structural modelling and simulation (including heterogeneous agents and return dispersion) aligns with the advanced analysis required in program evaluation and economic assessment.

2. My programming and data-handling skills (Python, R, Stata, large survey and administrative data) match CAPE's expectation for rigorous quantitative analysis, transparency, and reproducibility.
3. I have a proven ability to communicate complex quantitative findings in clear, policy-relevant terms, which is essential for advisory roles that support senior leadership and inter-agency coordination.

I am excited about the opportunity to contribute my empirical modelling and analytic skills to CAPE's landscape of strategic economic evaluation and decision support. Thank you for considering my application.

Sincerely,

Decory Edwards